

From Gambling to Storytelling: Reimagine Slot Games for Intersectional Narratives in Kevin

Zihan Feng*

Games and Simulation Arts and Sciences
Rensselaer polytechnic institute
Troy, New York, USA
fengz5@rpi.edu

Peiran Hu

Donghua University
Shanghai, China
xijiangyue__0@163.com

Abstract

Contemporary video games often equate narrative agency with complex player choices, thereby complicating interface design. This study challenges this trend by developing *Kevin*, a slot game that integrates simplistic haptic interaction into interactive storytelling. *Kevin* is designed based on the common 243-way slot games, with gameplay centered around the protagonist Kevin's college life. Furthermore, we root our narrative design in the intersectionality framework by exploring the multifaceted nature of Kevin's identities. Based on player feedback, we found that the contrast between the simple button interaction and the game's visual storytelling creates compelling narrative tension. However, we also identified certain limitations in balancing critical perspectives with dramatic plots and addressing ludic literacy. Accordingly, we propose directions for future research and design looking to repurpose slot games.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → Computers in other domains; Personal computers and PC applications; Computer games.

Keywords

Slot games, interactive storytelling, intersectionality, agency, emergent narrative, haptic interface

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1 Introduction

As of today, a significant portion of game studies, especially those focusing on interactive storytelling, remain committed to the belief that agency is essential to the game experience [1]. Although debates over what constitutes agency have persisted since Janet Murray famously defined agency as “the satisfying power to take

meaningful action and see the results of our decisions and choices” [2, p.126], certain keywords, such as free will, choice, and control, recur in relevant discussions. Although recent studies on gameplay agency have tried to understand from other perspectives such as aesthetics and embodiment [8, 23], narrative-heavy games have continued to reinforce the well-known agency keywords in their interface design. By reviewing popular narrative-heavy games on the gaming platform Steam, one will quickly notice such games often market themselves with tags like open world, multiple paths/endings, and choice matters. When playing these games, players have to adapt themselves to increasingly complex storytelling and decision-making interfaces.

A game genre that is rarely associated with storytelling is slot games. Slot games are well-known for their simplistic haptic interaction and widespread use in gambling activities, which has led relevant research often focus on their addictive mechanics and numeric systems [4], while overlooking their function of storytelling. The single button or level as an interface seems to be naturally at odds with the trend of pursuing complex decision-making among narrative-heavy games. However, after decades of evolution, modern slot games have incorporated various multimodal elements from other game genres to engage players, including the ones related to storytelling, such as character-building and worldbuilding [5, 6]. Given these circumstances, several questions arise: Can slot games, along with the unique interface they represent, be used for the purpose of interactive storytelling? If so, what are their strengths and limitations?

We started our design-based research with these questions in mind. Throughout this research, we found that slot games are particularly well-suited for generating intersectional narratives, and designed the game *Kevin* based on this finding. *Kevin* is a slot game unique for its gameplay driven by engagement with the life story of the protagonist Kevin instead of numeric attributes like money. Besides exploring slot games as a medium for storytelling, *Kevin* also further highlights the broader possibilities of narrative agency in interface design. In the following section, we introduce the background topics that inform the development of *Kevin*.

2 Related works

2.1 Slot games and interactive storytelling

Although existing studies on slot games rarely discuss their narratives, these studies still reveal some important features of slot games that demonstrate storytelling potential. In her book *Addiction by Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas*, Schüll reports a comprehensive investigation into slot games and points out that these games often use mathematical algorithms to simulate randomness,

*Corresponding author

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giving players a sense of luck and hope [4]. Since players cannot access the underlying algorithms of slot games, the randomly generated outcomes are entirely presented through the interface, which dovetails neatly with the concept of emergent narrative in game design. Emergent narrative refers to stories that are not pre-determined but instead arise dynamically according to players' interaction with the game [7]. In this sense, the unpredictable event experiences offered by emergent narratives are very similar to the sense of luck felt by slot game players. Moreover, the continuously generated outcomes of slot games can be combined with story elements to effectively create emergent narratives.

The physical part of the slot game interface, that is, the arm to pull or the button to press, is also generally overlooked in academic discussions. However, as media archaeologist Huhtamo has discovered, the straightforward physical interaction of slot games inherits early human-machine interaction patterns and can be traced back to the 19th century [3]. The simplicity of the slot game interaction thus enables players to easily embody it as part of their sensory experience that connects the virtual game world and real-life [8]. Given this, we suggest that the haptic slot interaction can provide players with a sensory experience of control over the narrative, ultimately enhancing their sense of agency.

Notably, some game studies have begun experimenting with the use of slot games for storytelling purposes rather than gambling in recent years. However, these studies often fail to how the interface itself contributes to storytelling but simply categorize slot games as casual games [10], or use them as a source of gameplay inspiration instead [9]. Therefore, in our research, we aim to take a step forward in exploring the unique relationship between the haptic experience of slot games and storytelling, with the goal of identifying suitable narrative types and narration approaches for this particular genre.

2.2 Intersectional narratives

When selecting the narrative theme for this research, we decided to focus the storytelling on the development of a main character, as incorporating anthropomorphized characters to engage players is already a common practice among slot games [5]. As for building the character, we adopted intersectionality as our theoretical framework. Originally introduced by Crenshaw, intersectionality highlights that the struggles of multiply marginalized communities, such as black women, are caused by the interplay of multiple identities instead of a single one [11, 12]. Over the years, intersectionality has become a foundational theory in the humanities and social sciences, emphasizing the connection between individual lived experiences and the complexity of identities [13]. Especially in the fields of human-computer interaction (HCI) and critical game design, intersectionality has also become a guiding framework for enhancing inclusivity in terms of race, gender, sexuality, ability, and other aspects [21, 22].

We believe that intersectionality aligns well with storytelling slot games for two reasons. Firstly, since intersectional storytelling requires depicting a character from diverse identity dimensions, it demands plenty of narrative details, which can be effectively achieved through the emergent narratives generated in slot games. Secondly, the intersectional perspective can add unique critical



Figure 1: The setup of Kevin

depth to game narrative design, preventing it from enhancing sociocultural stereotypes or building flat characters. It is with these considerations that we created *Kevin*.

3 Game Design

3.1 Game overview

Kevin is a narrative-based and narrative-driven slot game that revolves around the protagonist *Kevin's* college life. As Figure 1 shows, the interface setup of *Kevin* consists of only a screen and a button (the keyboard is not needed). In terms of operation, *Kevin* is similar to most slot games, as players just need to press the button to spin the virtual reels, which will generate a random combination of symbols. However, these symbols in *Kevin* are not tied to money, but instead correspond to three aspects of *Kevin's* life experiences, including well-being, sociality, and professionalism. Each time the button is pressed, it represents a new day in *Kevin's* life with a piece of emergent narrative triggered by specific combinations of symbols. Although the stories are generated randomly, players still have agency in driving the narrative forward. Furthermore, since each playthrough produces a unique growth path for *Kevin*, it offers players a distinct adventure every time they engage with this game and helps build a personal connection between players and the character.

3.2 Narrative design

Based on the research interests and experience of the two group members, we designed *Kevin* as an Asian homosexual male college student studying in an American university environment. Figure 2 illustrates the logic framework we used for generating emergent narratives about *Kevin*. In this framework, randomness works on two levels. Firstly, we reference the common 243-way slot games to randomly generate 15 symbols each time [14], and the types and quantities of these symbols determine the theme and stakes of the upcoming event. Secondly, we also randomly generate *Kevin's* attitude toward these events, leading to different event outcomes. Furthermore, the event outcomes can modify *Kevin's* corresponding attribute values (well-being, sociality, and professionalism) or trigger prerequisites, recursively influencing subsequent events. For instance, when *Kevin* is assumed by his roommate to excel at math due to his Asian identity, he might choose to clarify the

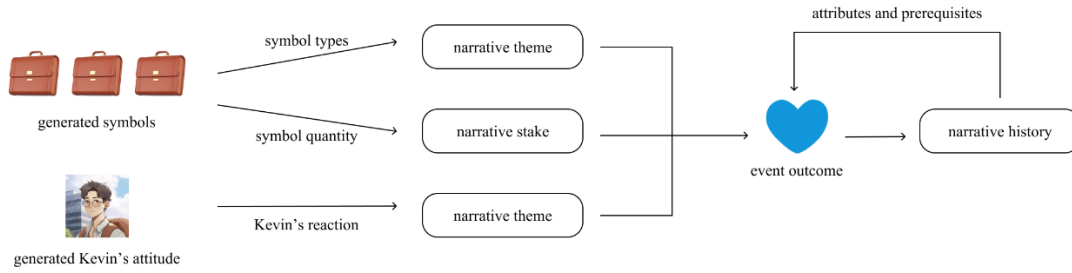


Figure 2: The framework to generate emergent narratives in *Kevin*

misunderstanding, reluctantly help with math problems, or, if he has a poor prior relationship with the roommate, start an argument. Through this framework, we aim to provide enough details to highlight how Kevin’s intersecting identities influence his daily life. Our message is clear: we should recognize the multifaceted nature of individuals’ lived experiences rather than making simple judgments based on stereotypes.

4 Interface Innovation

4.1 Interface design and iteration

The innovation of this project lies not only in matching a game genre traditionally unrelated to storytelling, namely, slot games, with interactive storytelling, but also in exploring how simplistic haptic interaction can create narrative agency. It is important to note that existing HCI research on haptic experiences for storytelling often focuses on diversifying multisensory feedback, which indicates a direction toward complex physical interface design [15, 16]. In contrast, we take a reverse approach, investigating how the dissonance between the simplest physical user input and rich narratives can create unique engaging experiences.

The interface innovation is further substantiated through our redesign of the regular slot game visual interface. We based our visual designs on the narrative game interface design principles proposed by Bizzocchi and colleagues [17], and specifically emphasized the principle of building a narrativized “look and feel”. As Figure 3 shows, in our initial prototype, we tried to display all the narrative-stylized elements on the screen, including the character Kevin, spinning reels, attribute progress bars, and the story text box. We assessed this prototype through user testing, in which 12 participants (9 university students, and 3 university staffs/faculties) were hired to play *Kevin* while performing the think-aloud protocol [18]. As a result, more than half of the participants noted that the contrast between the simple button interaction and slot game visuals with narratives creates an engaging tension that made the game compelling. However, we also collected feedback regarding the limitations of the prototype. Among these limitations, the most frequently mentioned issues included unclear player guidance for playing the game, a lack of dramatic impact in stories, and the heavy reliance on text to convey the narrative.

Based on the feedback we collected, we then made further adjustments to *Kevin*’s interface following the iterative design approach proposed by Maclin and Sharp [19]. Specifically, we enhanced the

gameplay instructions by adding an information bar and making clear the attribute values of Kevin. In addition, we expanded the space for displaying narratives and added extra time/date indicators to emphasize storytelling as the game’s core purpose (see Figure 3, right).

4.2 Critical reflection

Through the iterative game design, we gained a deeper understanding of both the strengths and weaknesses of utilizing slot games for interactive storytelling. Below are two points of reflection we summarized for future exploration.

Balancing critical perspectives and dramatic plots: During our user testing, many participants noted that due to the simplicity of *Kevin*’s haptic interaction, they expected the generated stories to be more dramatic and impactful. Their suggested improvements include extending the time span in narrative for every single press, or incorporating exaggerated plots. However, as our narrative design was fundamentally rooted in Kevin’s intersectional identities, there exists a tension between exaggerated storylines and the critical showcase of intersectionality. For future game designers aiming to integrate simplistic haptic experiences into storytelling, it is then essential to balance critical perspectives and dramatic narratives so that the game can engage players while maintaining its potential for positive social impact.

Considering the ludic literacy of slot games: Another notable phenomenon from user testing is that most of the participants experienced varying degrees of confusion in understanding *Kevin*’s gameplay, particularly regarding the arrangements of symbols and how they connect to the generated narrative. Such confusion sheds light on a lack of ludic literacy (or game literacy) of slot games, that is, previous knowledge about how this game genre works as media [20], and how this deficiency can significantly impact player experiences. Therefore, we suggest future game designers looking to repurpose slot games may consider incorporating them as recurring modules or mini-games within a larger game structure. In this way, players can progressively build familiarity with the mechanics and interface of slot games, ultimately having a more immersive engagement with the gameplay.

5 Conclusion

In this research, we have developed Kevin to redesign slot games for interactive storytelling. On the one hand, by incorporating

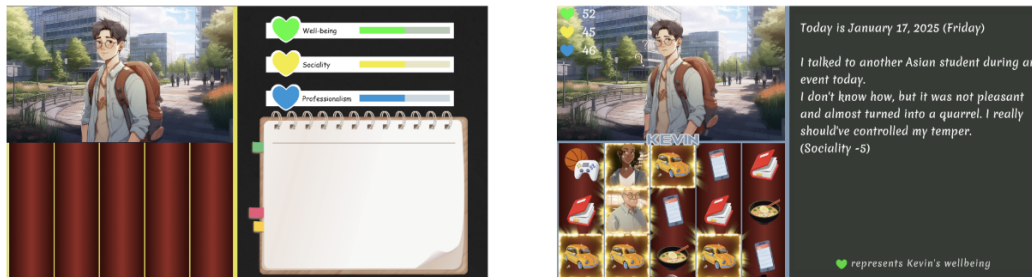


Figure 3: The initial (left) and final (right) design of *Kevin's* visual interface

simplistic haptic interaction, this game project challenges the prevailing trend in narrative-heavy games that equate agency with complex player choices. On the other hand, it also breaks free from traditional perceptions that limit slot games and their interface to gambling activities. We have presented the theoretical background, development process, interface innovation, and critical reflection of Kevin in this paper. We believe that with these insights, Kevin can serve as a source of inspiration for future narrative game design and research. More importantly, we see this game project as an expansion of possibilities for game HCI research by bridging interface design ideas across game genres.

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